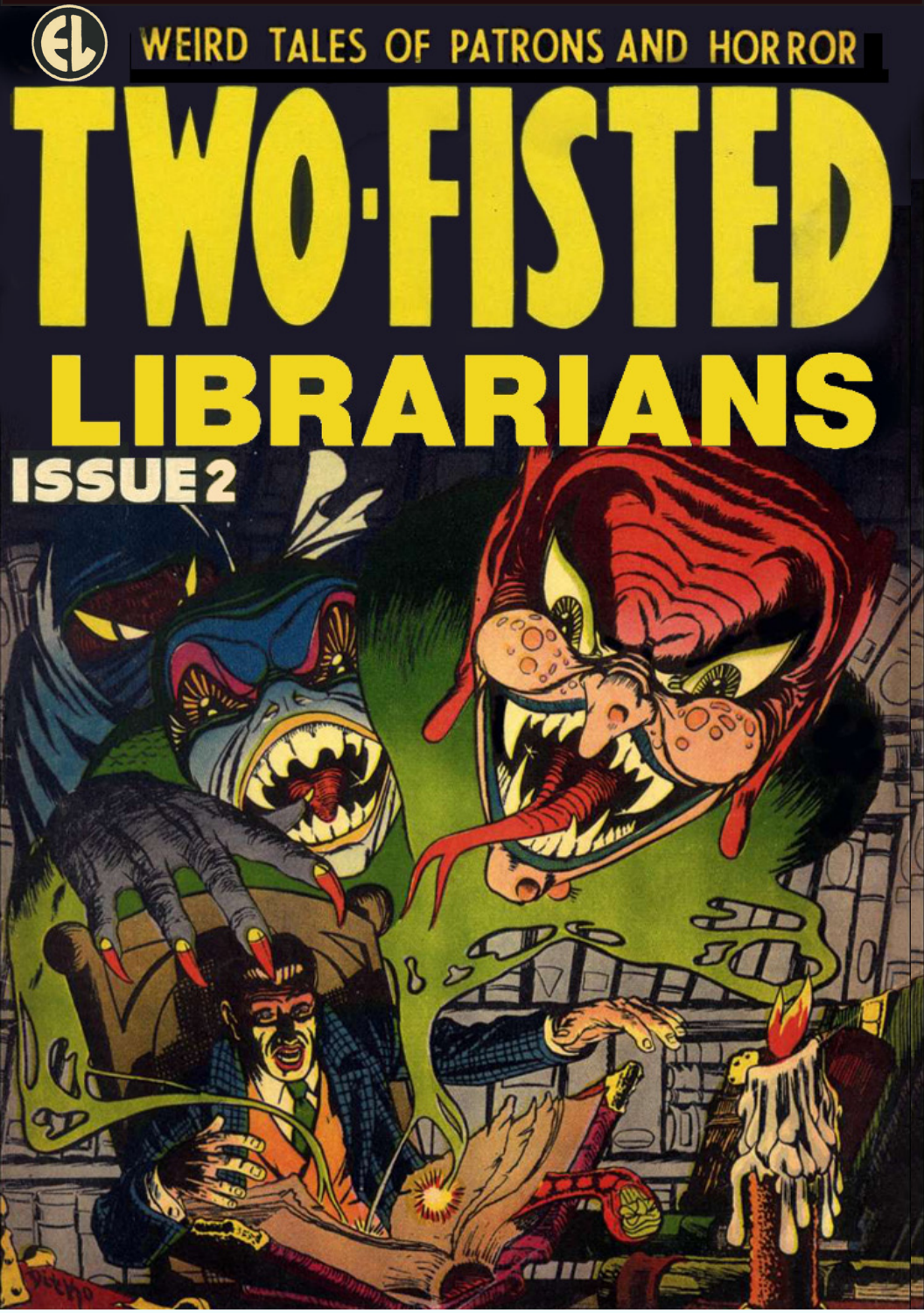

"I can't vouch for its quality." - Ben Blacker, co-writer for the Thrilling Adventure Hour and Wolverine: Season One

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by Matthew Murray

THE SOUTH BAY POST

A Member of the Associated Press.

Illustrated Weekly Newspaper

Est. 1869 Wednesday, November 24, 1921 Price 6p

ARSONIST TORCHES LIBRARY

Mysterious arsonist sets light to local library.

By Ms. Adena Brons

The port town of South Bay was shocked last Friday night when an unknown man set fire to the municipal library. The blaze began shortly after sundown and although fire crews were quickly on the scene, they were too late to quell the inferno.

Our reporter was unable to determine just how many of the library's precious books may have been saved. Eyewitness accounts claim that the South Bay librarian, Verity Vertue, was seen pulling books from the flames. Ms. Vertue disappeared shortly after the fire trucks arrived and has not been seen since. With the head librarian, Baddock Barnacle, away on unknown business, and Ms. Vertue likewise disappeared, there is no one remaining in South Bay who can determine the extent of the damage.

The police have requested that anyone with knowledge that may be relevant to the cause of the fire to contact them immediately.

THE SOUTH BAY POST

A Member of the Associated Press.

Illustrated Weekly Newspaper

Est. 1869 - Wednesday, December 7, 1921 - Price 6p

BARNACLE NOWHERE TO BE FOUND

Insurance company attempts to contact missing librarian.

Suresafe Insurance reports attempting to reach South Bay librarian Baddock Barnacle numerous times at his local residence. Barnacle's landlady, a Mrs. Trubott, told this reporter that Barnacle has not been seen for weeks. All mail has been forwarded to an address in Valparaíso. Suresafe Insurance has reportedly telegrammed Barnacle there.

Barnacle was the head librarian of the recently destroyed South Bay Library. He took over the position seven years ago after returning from a lengthy sea voyage.

Rescued Books Find Permanent Home with Eccentric Collector

The remaining books of the South Bay Library have been taken into the custody of Dr. Sinextrus, a wealthy collector of antiquities. In a statement to the press, Dr. Sinextrus said "It is my wish to help preserve the knowledge and learning of the past. If I can offer a safe home to the displaced books resulting from this unfortunate conflagration, I will feel I am doing a service to our fine community."

Dr. Sinextrus lives in a mansion in the hills just outside South Bay. His private security is said to be formidable so no further harm is likely to come to the recovered volumes.

THE SOUTH BAY POST

A Member of the Associated Press.

Illustrated Weekly Newspaper

Est. 1869 - Wednesday, December 14, 1921 Price 6p

PLANS TO REBUILD LIBRARY SABOTAGED

Bizarre accidents plague work site in new library construction

As construction begins on the South Bay Library, the builders are having to deal with numerous incidents of sabotage and unusual accidents.

Police have been called to the scene repeatedly to deal with increasingly strange matters. The first incident occurred before construction even began, with a large shipment of bricks going missing en route from the brickyard, only 3 miles away. The two truckloads of bricks have yet to be found.

The second incident was more sinister. Scaffolding built around the building site had nails removed and boards split during the night, resulting in three workers falling. One was unharmed but two remain in hospital.

The third instance occurred only yesterday. At 1:25am the police received a report that strange lights had been seen at the site. When they arrived, the site was deserted but there were scorch marks and evidence of fire. One investigator reported that the evidence suggested an unusual substance was burned, perhaps a type of paint or chemical.

One has to ask, who is trying to sabotage the South Bay Library?

THE SOUTH BAY POST

A Member of the Associated Press.

ILLUSTRATED WEEKLY NEWSPAPER

Est. 1869 — Wednesday, December 21, 1921 — Price 6p

WHERE IS BADDOCK BARNACLE?

Valparaíso address a dead end.

By Ms. Adena Brons

Investigations into the Valparaíso address provided by Barnacle prove inconclusive. According to Chilean officials, the address is not for a boarding house or hotel but is in fact the local library. The librarian at Valparaíso is not known to have any association with Barnacle and denies all knowledge of him or any mail addressed to him.

SOUTH SEAS PIRATES

Exhibition Open at Maritime Museum

Dec 21-31

Explore the Orient with the

SOUTH SEAS PIRATES

Private Zeppelin Whisks Dr. Sinextrus off to Secret Location.

The private dirigible belonging to the eccentric Dr. Sinextrus was seen tethered to the roof of his hilltop mansion early last evening. The zeppelin set sail shortly after dawn this morning. Sinextrus' destination is unknown.

Dr. Sinextrus took up residence in South Bay approximately two years ago after reputedly making his fortune in Romania as a medical engineer. He is a noted recluse and rarely receives visitors. Recently, readers may remember, he volunteered to house the remaining books saved from the library fire.

THE INFORMINATRIX Vs. THE BOOK THIEF

Irina Jevlakova
Writer/Plot/Script

ARCHER FISHBIRD, a shy mild-mannered librarian, has a secret - at night, he transforms into THE INFORMINATRIX! Fighting to protect books and information everywhere, immense powers of telepathy and a photographic memory allow her to stop villains who would seek to destroy the intellectual freedom we take for granted. Whether its censorship, burning books, or simply a volume lost to the mists of time, THE INFORMINATRIX is there!

It began when Archer started noticing strange disappearances from the catalog; books would go missing one by one over a period of several weeks. Not checked out, simply gone without a trace. Moreover, it seemed as though when one title disappeared, all copies went with it... Thefts were not a rare thing in libraries, but the items stolen were usually the popular fictions rather than the mish-mash of books he saw here. Historical accounts, academic treatises, dramatic novels... all gone without a trace. He tried looking for patterns in the kinds of books that were vanishing - all had different authors, titles, years of publication. Wherever the secret lay, it was not in the descriptive metadata. So he dug deeper, looking at subject headings, call numbers, contents, anything to give him an idea of what tied these books to each other.

The answer came on a stormy evening, amidst piles of catalog cards splayed out on the living room floor - he had been staring at them for hours, trying to make connections, to think like the enemy must have thought in committing the theft. As a flash lighting illuminated the apartment, suddenly, he understood!

Love. That was what all the books had in common. But not any ordinary kind, not the sort one finds in dog-eared romance novels on

the nightstands of housewives. No, this was the kind of love that did not speak its name, the kind some people would see as a disease, a perversion on normality. The sort that in this day and age was tolerated, if not accepted, or so he thought.

Archer sat back and took a deep breath. He thought of his occasional sidekick, The Decimal Demon, and her impending wedding to the famous novelist Katrina Wellington. Demon knew nothing about Archer - to her, he was only The Informinatrix, someone she looked up to and fought fiercely to protect. Even though their day-to-day lives were a mystery, fighting crime on the rain-slick city streets had brought them closer than any friend he had made before or since. Whoever was behind the book thefts, they threatened her life - and indirectly, his.

The next night, after the library had closed, Informinatrix set up a watch of the back entrance, hoping to catch the criminals red-handed. And sure enough, before long she saw two men exit carrying a stack of books each. Her mind exploded with questions - how had they entered the library after hours? Had they simply walked in like regular patrons, hiding out of sight when the security guard came around to make sure nobody had been left behind? The henchmen rounded a corner into an alley, and tossed the books unceremoniously into a waiting truck. She winced, as if it was she herself that had been so casually mishandled, but not before noting the number of the license plate. I must find out why they're rounding up all these books! she thought. Before they get away for good!

Using her powers of telepathy, the Informinatrix found out the location the truck was headed, and by the time it reached its destination she confronted the two henchmen by blocking the gate into the warehouse complex.

"Hey, what are you doing? Get out of the way!" The yelled.

"Don't you know it's wrong to steal?" She said with a smirk. As they lunged at her, she disposed of them efficiently, leaving the pair in a bruised and beaten pile beside the gate. Years of shelving books had made her stronger than she seemed. The building seemed heavily armed, and she knew better than to go in unprepared. She used a nearly payphone to leave a message at the library letting them know

that some of their books had been found at the warehouse, and returned home.

When he arrived at the library, Archer knew he had to act quickly. He began by consulting the archives of the City Planning Office for architectural plans of the building and maps of the surrounding area. This would give him an idea of the best way to enter the warehouse without drawing attention. He also found a technical manual for the model of coded lock used to secure the gate, memorizing the procedure for emergency shut-off. Archer knew that with information, with knowledge, anything was possible! And books, well - books were the source of that knowledge. With books, anyone could learn anything they wanted, become whatever they wanted. That scared some people, enough to want to limit what books could be read and by whom. He wanted desperately to find the mastermind behind this plan; someone was definitely orchestrating the thefts, but why? And what had they planned to do with the stolen books? Was there something in them, a secret or code? He had heard of mystical volumes that, when brought together, would give their owner immense powers, but found it hard to believe that this was the case now. No matter what he found, he was ready - the Informinatrix was ready!

Finally the night had come. Armed with her telepathic powers and her fighting skills, the Informinatrix made her way into the warehouse, scaling the wall in order to make her approach from above. This way she could isolate the man in charge, perhaps use him to force the rest of the henchmen to stand down. The maps of the building showed a large central room, and through the ceiling windows she could see candles flickering around a red carpet. She laughed quietly - villains always seemed to have more ceremony than sense. In the middle of it all lay piles of books, strewn haphazardly in large piles. One person in particular, clad in a long black robe, looked as though he was surveying the scene rather than doing any work. He must be the one, the Book Thief as she has taken to calling him. He barked more orders and retreated to another room as the Informinatrix followed him with her telepathic powers. An air vent provided her the entrance she needed, and soon she was right over his head, ready to make her entrance.

With a powerful kick to the grate of the air vent, she leaped into the middle of the room. As the man turned around in surprise, she

immediately immobilized him by shooting out a pair of cables covered in the strongest book glue that could be found.

"I am The Informinatrix," she said, "and I've come to find out why you're stealing books!"

"I won't tell you anything!"

She tightened the cables. "Speak, or I will kill you!"

The Book Thief laughed.

"Fine. How about I'll tell you what I know first? I know you're only stealing certain kinds of books. I've figured out your pattern, thanks to this wonderful thing called subject headings." She smirked under her mask. "Anyone could have, really. Any idiot who knows how to use a card catalog could have figured you out. So WHY?"

"Because it's sick, that's why. It's disgusting, what this world has come to. Women marrying women; men raising children together -- un-natural, don't you see?"

"You're wrong, Book Thief! They are people just like you and me. If you thought for a moment about the people you--"

"Oh but you're wrong! Dead wrong! I don't care about that. No, my plan is much more better than that. You see, the books will persist much longer than I will. After I'm gone, the books will reflect this ugly world that I failed to change. So I thought, why not get rid of the books instead? Once all the books are gone, all of them, nobody will know about any of this! And if nobody knows about it, then it doesn't exist!"

Something didn't add up, though. "Alright, so you gather all these books, then what. What do you plan to do? Burn them? Lock them up? Eventually someone will find out."

"Oh no, nothing quite so simple. You see, a ship will leave this city tomorrow, bound for the Mariana Trench--"

"The deepest part of the ocean..." She said.

“Yes! All these books, and others like them, from all over the world, will be dumped there, never to return!”

He began laughing maniacally, and did so for about a minute or so before a dark shape descended from the ceiling and knocked him out.

The Informinatrix smiled. “I could have handled him myself, you know.”

Decimal Demon dusted off her gloves and returned the smile. “I know, but he was getting on my nerves.”

As she surveyed the books piled in the center of the room while Decimal Demon phoned the police, she wondered how many others had already been lost; perhaps this was the first place The Book Thief had struck, or the twentieth. They had been able to save the ones here, but how many more will suffer the same fate? For the time being, Archer would have his hands full trying to get them back on the shelf.

Submersion

By Ean Henninger

Aberdeen Kepler hit the chilly Pacific water with a dull splash that rushed into his ears and subsided into a trickle of bubbles fizzing upwards. He experienced a moment of directionless uncertainty as he sank through the water, then he oriented himself to the sun overhead and the vague shadow of the highway overpass that he and his partner had been tracking for the last couple of hours. So far the overpass had yielded nothing better than a small, half-aired car with a few magazines visible in the back seat, but he was hoping for a big find before the day was out. If he found a large haul, he'd mark the spot with a float and bring a salvage party back the next day. In his opinion, there was nothing that better demonstrated Cascadian resourcefulness than the fact that a ragtag group of people in boats could raise a derelict car from roads hundreds of feet below the surface and bring it back to shore.

In the beginning, immediately after the Rising, humanity had concerned itself with basic subsistence in a world smothered by ash and water, but then people began to reestablish the extended family as a social institution, and from that sprang small clans and villages scattered over mountains and hilltops. After some years, the hurting world's governments started reasserting themselves and set new boundaries, geographically and otherwise. The United States' East Coast was more than half gone, making the former Midwest even more of a misnomer. With the District of Columbia fully submerged, the current government had moved to Denver, well away from the waterlogged mess of the continent's new coasts.

“The comet did that much, anyway,” Aberdeen's grandfather would say. “No more sapheads asking me if I meant D.C. when I said I was from Washington.” Governmental continuity had been kept intact to a degree—rumor had it that the original Constitution and Declaration of Independence had even been saved and stored somewhere in the

Rockies—but rebuilding the crippled government was a constant challenge, and spreading law and order to outlying regions was beyond its current capacities, coping as it was with all the refugees who had fled as far inland as possible.

The comet had taken the world completely by surprise. The initial shockwaves, earthquakes, and tsunamis had killed off much of Earth's coastal population, especially in the Southern Hemisphere, and the Rising had done the rest. Antarctica's ice cover was gone, vaporized by the impact and cycled into the atmosphere. Warming caused by volcanic ash had made Greenland and the Arctic melt too. Nobody was quite sure by how much the sea had risen, but most guesses hovered around 150 meters. With more than a third of the world's former population living less than 100 meters above sea level, the Rising had been more than enough to cause massive death and migrations.

Those remaining in what had become the region of Cascadia struck out on their own to create order and to make a living by fishing and boating out on the Puget Sea. Many of them had taken to searching underwater cities and towns in the hopes of finding material resources to salvage for a profit or for their own use, but Aberdeen was interested in the formerly dry coastal regions for a different reason: information.

Aberdeen's grandfather had immediately seen the importance of books and other sources of information to rebuilding society, but so much knowledge had been burned, submerged, and otherwise lost that he had had his work more than cut out for him. Almost seventy years later, his descendants and their companions were still laboring to accomplish his mission of safeguarding the transmission of information through the post-Rising chaos.

The Keplers were virtually unique among clans for their attachment to the fairly abstract work of collecting, interpreting, and propagating information. Aberdeen's sister Astoria and her husband were itinerant instructors, while his cousin Wallingford was into research and currently pursuing the exciting possibility that “Tom Sawyer” was something more than a Canadian rock song from a hundred years ago. For his part, Aberdeen preferred to be out finding new sources of knowledge. He had shown a knack for finding stashes of documents even as a child, and that was just what he was attempting to do now. Aberdeen had been alive for twenty-three years and one of his clan's Retrievals librar-

ians for six of those years, and he had never intentionally lost a book on a salvage mission in all that time.

As Aberdeen pushed through the ashen, blue-gray ocean, a tilted rectangle grew out of the dim water below him. Drawing closer, he identified it as a semi truck hanging off the overpass by its cab. It had probably been there since its driver abandoned it to be pushed about by the countless tsunamis and storm surges that had battered the coasts during the Rising. Even better, he could now make out the famous Amazondotcom logo on its side. While not as good a find as one of the legendary storehouses, it was almost guaranteed to contain books. Aberdeen eagerly pumped his legs, propelling himself downward as the water pressed against his body. He rapped on the side of the trailer as he reached it, and it resounded hollowly in return. That meant it was solidly aired, so the water hadn't infiltrated it too much, but an imploding pressure in his chest warned him that he would need more air if he was going to explore the truck for any reasonable length of time.

Aberdeen turned and swam back towards the bulky silhouette of one of his clan's exploratory boats. It was essentially a trimaran—two paddleboats lashed and bolted to the sides of a canoe that held most of the supplies, plus some decking here and there for more surface area. A last few powerful kicks were enough to take Aberdeen up out of the water, and he pulled himself over the edge of the boat and rolled onto its makeshift deck in front of Queen Anne Martinez, his Retrievals apprentice for the day. She wasn't actually royal; she had been named for a hill in Seattle, and people who didn't drop the “Queen” in her name would often find themselves dropped into the nearest body of water. Many of those who lived through the Rising had taken to naming their children after lost cities, towns, and neighborhoods, and their children had gone on to make a tradition of it. Books of baby names, where they existed, had been supplanted by old maps and atlases.

“We've got a likely find,” Aberdeen said after taking some deep breaths. “I'm going to need the scuba gear and a specimen bag.” Queen Anne nodded and pulled back a tarp on the central canoe. She passed him the swimming gear and a waterproof bag, striving for professionality.

“Good find?” she asked.

“Aired semi truck,” Aberdeen said, carefully strapping the apparatus around his chest. He handled his scuba gear with almost as much care as he did books and other sources of information. Underwater gear was one of the many things that had been stockpiled during the Rising, but requisitioning it from the government was currently all but impossible. Aberdeen's scuba equipment had been found on a grounded derelict and restored to working order by his mother. The difficulty now was finding enough oxygen tanks to stay ahead of the demand. Aberdeen tried to make dives without assistance as much as he could and use the scuba only sparingly, but he had a hunch that this find might be worth it.

“I'm going to collect a couple of artifacts to make sure the content is solid and the trailer's worth bringing up,” he explained. “Standard procedure for wrecks of this size.”

“I'll be ready with the floats if so,” Queen Anne replied. “Best of luck to you.” Aberdeen gave a lazy salute and fell over the side of the boat. His fins pushed firmly against the cool water as he returned to the truck. The sun being out made for decent visibility even on the underside of the bulk that now loomed over him. He examined the back door—it looked like it would slide up, if he could get it open. The trailer was at such an angle that the water wouldn't encroach too much on the treasure inside. He removed a couple of tools from his wetsuit's belt and tested the door's fasteners. Years of exposure to seawater had corroded the metal surfaces, and they snapped off with only a little effort. The door was trickier, but Aberdeen managed to pry it open enough to make out a dim cardboard kaleidoscope staring down at him. The truck's fall had jumbled its boxes in such a way that he was able to ease the back door open even further without making them collapse. He teased a couple of packages from the blockage and slipped them into his bag, being careful not to let them touch the water that lapped at the sides of the truck. He then braced himself against the metal bottom of the truck and carefully pulled the door back down, but he couldn't avoid an ominous creaking magnified by the water. He kicked away from the truck and watched it intently for a few seconds. Some unsettled detritus drifted down the trailer's back in eddies, but it seemed to be stable.

Aberdeen left the truck on its precarious perch and headed for the surface. Even if the truck didn't have much in the way of books, coastal communities such as his clan did well for themselves by collecting bounties on useful pieces of technology from which the shaky inland

scientific infrastructure could reverse-engineer helpful devices. He was eager to examine the two boxes he had taken. He surfaced off the side of the boat and removed his breathing tube. Droplets arced off the bag and returned to the ocean as he swung it onto the deck.

“We've got company,” Queen Anne informed him, staring intently at something on the horizon.

“Good or bad?” Aberdeen asked, hanging off the side of the boat.

“I'm not sure,” she said. Aberdeen pulled himself up onto his arms and looked across their boat at the one in the distance. He could just make out a limp banner of red and white hanging from a thin mast.

“Canadians,” he said grimly.

“Probably just some innocent fisherman out for a pleasure cruise down south in American waters,” Anne shrugged.

“Not so.” Aberdeen shook his head at the beer bottles roped around the boat at intervals. Anne noticed them too and cursed.

“Everetts!”

While border enforcement was admittedly low on the list of the government's priorities, and immigration from one country to the other was quite relaxed inland, people out here had good reason to be ticklers about their borders. If Canadians were this far south and this open about their nationality, they had to be with the Everett clan. Aberdeen himself had had some tense encounters with Everetts, but he had never had cause to actually fight any of them. It was a wide, wet world, and though the location of the U.S.-Canadian marine border was a matter of some contention, each side could usually conduct its business without running afoul of the other's.

However, there were exceptions. Aberdeen's family and other Cascadian clans had been feuding with the Everetts ever since people had begun to settle the new coasts and reclaim things from the old ones. While the Keplers and their friends were devoted to recovering lost information from the depths, the Everetts had a lucrative business

pillaging underwater buildings for alcohol and other loot, which they then passed on at cost to clans further inland. They were singularly unscrupulous in their endeavors, and their general disregard for human life, not to mention books, put them distinctly at odds with the Keplers. Aberdeen's father had lost an ear while trying to keep a phone book out of the hands of some Everetts who wanted it for the locations of Bellingham liquor stores, and that was far from the worst of it.

Aberdeen lowered himself out of sight of the approaching boat and considered his course of action. Everetts were guaranteed to be armed and just as likely to be ruthless if they found something they wanted. He needed to find a way give himself and Anne the advantage. Possibilities sped through his head, and he made a decision just as quickly.

“Okay,” he told Anne, “odds are they haven't seen me. I'm going to go back down, then come up again as if for the first time. Pass me that length of rope, and don't do anything rash until I get back.” He paused. “'Rash' includes fighting them. Stay alive. I'll be quick.” He knew she had a level head on her shoulders, but he felt responsible for his apprentice nonetheless. She tossed off a mock salute, and Aberdeen let go of the deck and dropped into the sea.

* * *

The first thing Aberdeen saw upon coming out of the water was a pair of Everetts, a man and a woman, dragging a struggling Queen Anne onto their boat. He had seen the two boats near each other as he came up from the truck and hastened his activities accordingly, but there was nothing he could do about it without compromising his plan. Besides, he was confident in Queen Anne's ability to take care of herself, and they hadn't killed her yet, which was probably a good thing. However, the male Everett was now holding a knife to her throat, which, combined with the sight of Aberdeen, managed to make her still.

The Canadian pirates noticed Aberdeen too as he pulled himself onto the deck and took off his mask and hood. The one not holding Anne hostage made to cross back over and accost Aberdeen, but Aberdeen grabbed a spear from where it had been hidden under a tarp and hoisted it into the air, holding the rogue Canadian at bay. Stalemate. For now.

The faintly rocking boats began to drift away from each other as the waves slapping against them relaxed from their recent burst of activity. Aberdeen didn't recognize these Everetts, so presumably they didn't recognize him. That was also a plus. Probably. He just needed to stay calm and collected.

“All right,” he said, “I'm Kelso Smith, and that's my wife, Centralia. We're prospectors up from the St. Helen's Isles, and we don't want any fight. Just return my wife and we'll go our separate ways. In fact,—”

“You're a soggy lying Kepler!” The woman shouted.

“Why, what makes you think that?” Aberdeen asked innocently.

“You have your father's ears.” The man growled. Aberdeen winced as an image of Everett children studying the precise shape and size of his father's lost ear flashed unbidden through his mind.

“So that's got around...” His mind stalled trying to think of ways to keep stalling.

“Who might you be, then?” he asked brightly, pretending that the guns visible in the Everetts' prow weren't making him at all uneasy.

“We're Everetts, you mudbrain.”

“Well, obviously. But I was hoping we could reach a first-name basis before you did...whatever it is you're going to do.”

“I'm Nanaimo and she's Sydney,” the man said, grudgingly. “Now surrender your boat.”

“Your parents are Victoria and Vancouver, aren't they?” Anne said. Aberdeen admired her courage. Even in an atmosphere of extreme pessimism, she was staying calm enough to pick up on what he was trying to do. She'd make a good librarian, given the chance.

“That's got piss-all to do with anything,” Nanaimo said, adjusting his grip on both Anne and his knife. “We've already taken about the only valuable thing on your boat, save the boat itself. You can either give us the boat and swim away from all this or try and fight us for it and your

so-called 'wife.' You have five seconds to choose." He paused and, evidently deciding that he wasn't making himself sufficiently clear, began to count. "Five...four...three..."

"Wait!" Aberdeen stared intently at their boat, then looked up and forced a smile. "I'm only too happy to take a swim," he said quickly, laying down the spear, "but before we go our separate ways, wouldn't you like to know what we were doing here?"

"Like we care what a couple of bookscuts like you are dicking about on the sea for?"

"As it pertains to salvage? You might. Because there is a stash full of books down there."

"Books!" Nanaimo spat.

"Well, books and wine." Aberdeen removed one of the boxes from the bag hanging off his side without taking his eyes off the Everetts and their boat. "That's why I was down there just now. The two go together surprisingly well, and the wine had the appearance of quality, no doubt. I'd certainly be willing to split the spoils with you if we can come to a compromise of sorts."

"No compromise," Sydney said. "Beer is better than wine, anyway. It's her and your ship or you and your precious books." Aberdeen pulled back a corner of the box's cardboard flaps and peeked inside.

"Oh, believe me," he said, "I've made my choice." He flung the box across the water between the two boats and was relieved to see it glance off Nanaimo's head with a wet thud and slide into the water. Queen Anne took full advantage of the situation, elbowing her stunned captor in the gut and lunging away from his knife at the same time. She dove off the boat as it juddered alarmingly. Finally, the front of the Everetts' boat broke free of the ocean with a sucking splash, even as its stern was firmly yanked down. Sydney tried to scramble up the tilted bow and aim a rifle at Aberdeen, but the boat gave one last lurch and launched her backwards into the sea.

Aberdeen reached over and helped Anne onto the boat as the Everetts sputtered increasingly inventive curses at them.

“Are you all right?” he asked her.

“No worries,” she waved him off, breathing hard. By unspoken agreement, they each took a seat and paddled energetically for several minutes to put distance between themselves and the foundering Everetts.

“So, tying the rope to the truck, then to their boat?” Queen Anne had to raise her voice over the steady churning of the water. “How'd you destabilize the truck and time its fall?” Aberdeen looked at the coastal horizon ahead of them and took as much salty air in through his nose as he possibly could. He was inordinately glad to be alive.

“I gave it a good solid kick and got very lucky with the timing,” he said. “That works unusually well for a lot of things.”

“I'm sorry about all those books,” Anne said. “It would have meant so much to your grandfather...” Aberdeen just laughed.

“I'm willing to take my chances. I made sure the truck was securely closed before I let it drop. It didn't have far to fall—just enough to give you an out, and that was more important than the chance of losing what's in the trailer.”

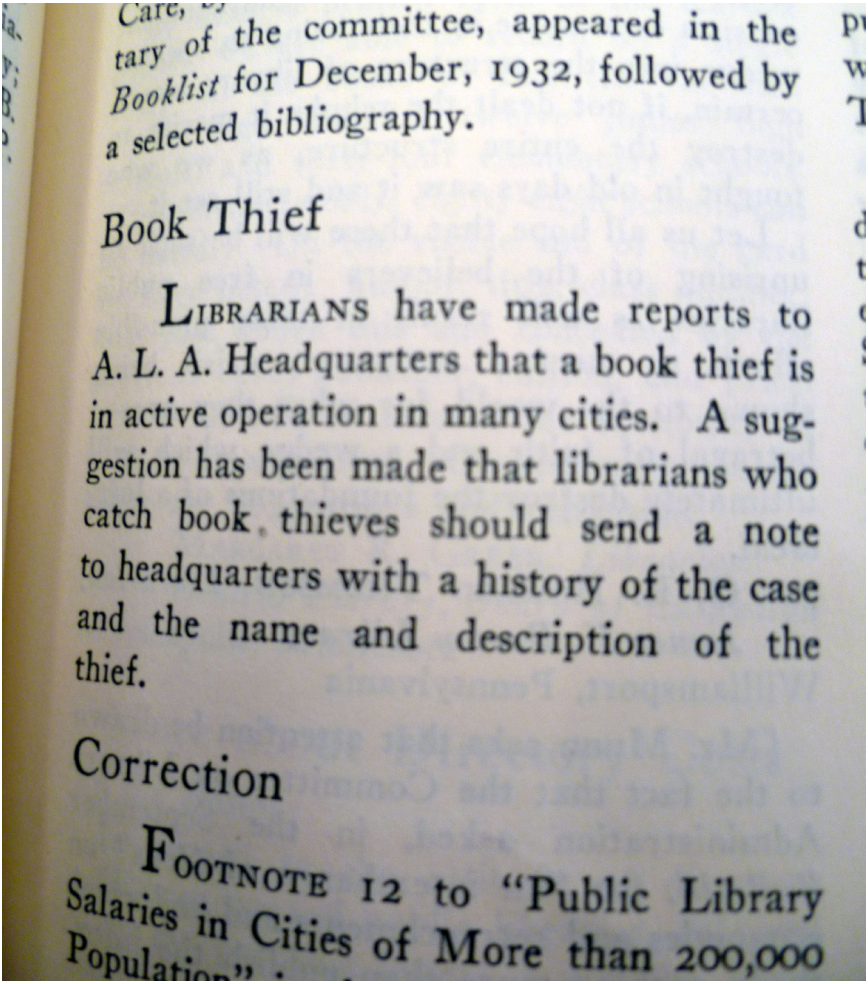
“But what about the book you threw at the Everetts?”

Aberdeen smiled and stopped paddling. “Can you keep a secret?” She nodded. “Before my grandfather died,” he continued, “he left us a very short list. It was a list of books that were so obviously popular as to be all but worthless, even in the post-Rising world. If the samples I grabbed were any indication, that trailer was full of them.” He took the copy he had saved out of its box and handed it over to her. She looked at its back cover and began to read:

About three things I was absolutely positive: First, Edward was a vampire. Second, there was a part of him–and I didn’t know how dominant that part might be–that thirsted for my blood. And third, I was unconditionally and irrevocably in love with him.

How to Steal a Book in 1930s Chicago

By Matthew Murray



Care, by

tary of the committee, appeared in the *Booklist* for December, 1932, followed by a selected bibliography.

Book Thief

LIBRARIANS have made reports to A. L. A. Headquarters that a book thief is in active operation in many cities. A suggestion has been made that librarians who catch book thieves should send a note to headquarters with a history of the case and the name and description of the thief.

Correction

FOOTNOTE 12 to "Public Library Salaries in Cities of More than 200,000 Population"

That was the entirety of the report that ran in an issue of ALA Bulletin in early 1933. Anyone who thought about it for more than a second realized that something was up, that there was something ALA wasn't telling us. Book thefts are common enough, hell, we've had plenty of books stolen from our library, but a single book thief active in multiple cities? How did they know it was just one person? What was the common factor? We'd sent in our reports, but had heard nothing official back and I had grown curious.

I'd planned on attending the 1933 ALA conference in Chicago anyway, it's always a pleasure to meet up with old colleagues and learn about the latest cataloguing techniques from Europe or Canada or wherever. Though, to be honest, I was more looking forward to checking out the World's Fair once the conference was finished.

I casually put the word out at the conference that I was looking for more information on this book thief. I said that I wanted to compare notes with other people. I talked to a lot of librarians, I guess a lot of books get stolen from libraries, but finally something jumped out at me. The lists of books stolen from libraries was never the same, but the title of one book kept showing up again and again: Malleus Maleficarum. I can't say I was an expert in whatever this book was, but it definitely seemed to be something magical related, and that started my alarm bells ringing.

I soon managed to gain the interest of a few other librarians who had some time on their hands after the conference. Of course I may have suggested that I had slightly more authority from ALA than I had. ALA had no idea I was even looking into this, and I wasn't about to tell them. We didn't really see eye to eye after the events surrounding the 1931 New Haven conference and Dr. Armitage's unfortunate field trip to visit the new Copeland wing of Miskatonic University's Orne Library.

There were six of us gathered around the table in the Stevens Hotel restaurant that Sunday morning in late October, the day after the conference had ended. There was Joanne "Sixgun" Dixon, who claimed to be going to library school somewhere "out west" but I don't think she ever said exactly where. Ernestine Castillo from a university down south somewhere, and this time she did tell us the name of the place, but I just plain forget. Lawrence Montgomery Underwood II who worked for the British Museum Library over in England, it turned out that they'd had their copy stolen the year before making this bigger than any of us suspected. Hattie Sheppard, who was doing some good work down in the Library of Congress and, to be honest, mostly just seemed embarrassed that anyone had even managed to steal something from there. Finally, there was Harry Grover, who didn't look like any Harry I'd ever met but had just started working for some fancy New York university.

They all knew that they were here about the book thefts, but they didn't know that it was one particular book that I wanted to know more about. I spilled everything I knew out, what little of it there was. That this book, the Malleus Maleficarum, had been stolen from all of our libraries, and from many others to boot. That ALA knew more than it was letting on, but wasn't telling us. And that maybe we should look into this a bit more.

The looks on their faces ranged from shock to excitement. And to be honest, an international campaign to steal one specific book was more exciting than what many librarians got up to in an average day. We spent a couple of hours throwing ideas back and forth, but we ran into a couple of problems we couldn't overcome. First, all the libraries in the city were closed, it being Sunday and all. Second, the ALA office would also have been closed, and after my last experiences there I wasn't so sure I'd be welcomed back with open arms. Third, none of us was that familiar with Chicago. And finally, none of us knew a damn thing about this book, which is why we wanted to head to a library in the first place.

Finally, I called an end to the whole thing. We'd started going in circles and nobody was adding anything new. "Tomorrow we can hit up the libraries," I said. "But today we can't, so I suggest a little diversion to the World's Fair. I know that's why I've got some extra time here, and I suspect that's why all of you aren't on trains back home already."

That got a round of agreements, and we soon headed off to check out the fairgrounds that had been built along the coast of Lake Michigan. It was supposed to celebrate a "century of progress" or something, and as much as I sometimes think humans have barely advanced in the last thousand years, let alone one hundred, I gotta say that some of the stuff on display there was pretty darn impressive.

We walked around some of the exhibit halls, and even in the day you could see that those were lit up in neon lights like nobody's business. You just knew that this place would look even more impressive at night time. Of course, it being Sunday they herded us all out of that place before it got dark enough to see the display. Thankfully the midway was still open, and while that place may not have been as full of "scientific marvels" or the "technology of tomorrow", it was certainly full of people despite the drizzle of the evening.

We walked through the cacophony of noise, music spilling out of restaurants, carnival barkers trying to get us to “step right up” and try our luck at some rigged game, or take a look at the “loveliest ladies around”. Eventually we found ourselves in the Streets of Paris, and despite what Mr. “I’ve been to Paris and this is nothing like it” (or “Lawrence Montgomery” to you and me) might say, I thought it was pretty swell.

I saw a sign advertising Sally Rand’s fan dance at the Paris Revue, and as much as I wanted to see it I didn’t relish trying to convince the others to come along with me, so I figured I’d just come back later. That was until Hattie saw the same poster, decided that if she didn’t get to see “the most sensuous woman in America” then the entire trip would be a waste, and herded the lot of us inside.

Now I’ll tell you that a lot of stuff in this story sounds pretty crazy, and there are definitely things that I don’t truly understand, but if there’s one thing that can be described as magic, then it’s Sally Rand’s fan dance. That girl is well known for a reason. And when she got up in front of that hall to do her act, you could have heard a pin drop. Every eye was on her, and damn, if she didn’t seem to glow under those lights.

After the show we stood around the bar (and I cannot say how thankful I am that prohibition is finally over) and, well, we just stood there until this guy came up to us and started asking questions. Now, I’m usually not the type to answer questions from anyone, let alone some weird, nervous looking stranger in a bar. But this guy was just asking us if we’ve seen his sister Nevilla Norman. We hadn’t, but I felt bad for the guy and so bought him a drink and we got to talking. Turns out his sister was a waitress in the Paris Revue, but nobody had seen her in a few days and he was getting worried.

Someone walked by and the guy quickly asked them if they’d seen Nevilla. “Sorry Frank, not since last time you asked” came the reply before they headed off.

“Wait, you’re Frank Norman?” asked Hattie. “The Snakeoid?”

At that Frank seemed to perk up. ‘Yes! That’s right, I’m the snakeoid, and can I say that it’s an honour that even a group of librarians have heard of me.”

“Well, we haven’t all heard of you”, I said, wanting to make sure he didn’t think he was a celebrity or anything. “How’d you end up with a name like that.”

“Well, I eat snakes. Live ones. It’s called the Monster Snake Show and is in the Odditorium. You should come check it out if you get a chance.”

Now I could tell that Mr. British Museum wasn’t too excited about checking out a place called the Odditorium, so I told Frank we’d definitely check it out if we got the chance, which seemed to please Hattie. Then he handed her a playbill advertising the show and took off.

After that the group drifted apart in a haze that was in no small part fueled by alcohol. I have no idea where the others ended up, and nor do I care. Not that it mattered much, as we’d all planned to meet up the next morning and head to the University of Chicago library and find out more about this mysterious book.

The next morning we met up in the same breakfast place in the hotel, and you could tell that this time some people weren’t so happy about the early start, myself included. Still, we actually had a goal today, and hopefully it wouldn’t involve any more freak show folks.

When we got to the university library we saw that it was bustling with students. “Great”, I thought to myself, thankful that I had left my student days long behind me. Still, at least the library was open. At first the librarian on duty seemed relieved when we came up to them, I’m sure students asking for help for assignments due the next day gets pretty old pretty fast.

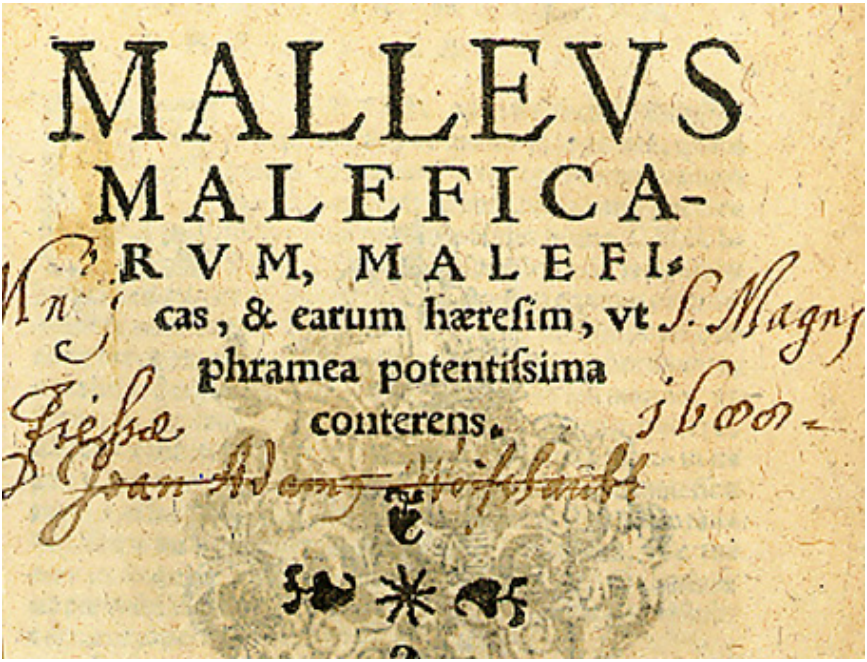
But once I dropped word that we were in town on ALA business, which was technically true as the whole reason we were in Chicago was for the conference, and that we’d appreciate her help in doing some research she froze up. Now I don’t know if it was because I was the one asking, if it was the ALA connection, or if it was the joke I dropped about her last name, but it didn’t look like Ms. Rachel Stoker was going to be any help. I was about to move on and try to find the damn book myself when Harry moved in and was far smoother than I expected him to be. Suddenly Ms. Stoker seemed game to help us, and

brought us back to the card catalogue that contained their classifications.

"Looks like we've got two editions of Malleus Maleficarum. Which one do you want to see?" The others looked at each other unsure of how to respond, but Harry said we'd take a look at both and we got led up to the rare book room.

Rachel found one of the books soon enough, but after a couple of minutes going through the shelves she turned to us.

"I can't find the other one, but our system says it should be in. Hmm," she paused. "Let me go and take a look in our system, and I'll be back in a bit."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Finally, we were able to take a look at the book that had brought us all together. Most of us had never seen a copy of the thing before. There it sat on the table. Big. Black. Bound in leather with metal hinges. It'd look imposing if it hadn't been falling apart. We opened it up and that thing was complete gibberish to me. Have you seen old German writing? No wonder they invented the printing press.

Ernestine said that it was in Latin, and for all I knew I just had to assume she was right. Her and Lawrence spent the next hour puzzling through the book, trying to translate at least some of it. The rest of us, well, we didn't have much to do. So when Rachel came back I jumped up at the hope that something would happen.

"The other copy of the book is supposed to be in", she said. "But I was able to dig up the last person who borrowed it, Dr. Waltraud Geiisshardt." She passed Harry a piece of paper with that written down on it, something I was thankful for because there was no way I was going to be able to spell that name. "It's possible that Dr. Geiisshardt still has it."

"Do you know anything about this person?" asked Harry.

"No, they're probably a professor somewhere on campus. I can't keep track of everybody," she looked a little exasperated. "Now, I'm sorry, but I have to get back to the desk. You can stay here until close if you like, though you can't take that book out of this room."

We decided to split up. Ernestine and Lawrence would stay and try to translate the book, while the rest of us would try to find the doctor. We looked him up in the campus directory, and saw that he was a visiting professor in the folklore department.

We headed over there, though it took us a while, you'd think they'd put up maps or something. Or at least put the damn folklore department on the maps. Still, we eventually found it crammed up into a corner of one of the older buildings. We headed through the door that featured a handwritten sign with Dr. Geiisshardt's name on it. Inside was an outer office with a secretary working away on a typewriter. Harry took the lead and asked if we could see the doctor.

"I'm sorry, Dr. Geiisshardt isn't in right now, can I take a message?" The secretary was being less than receptive.

"Yes ma'am", began Harry. "See, we're here from the library and we're looking for a missing book that we think Dr. Geiisshardt might have in his office.

The secretary shut down almost entirely upon hearing this.

“Dr. Geiisshardt is sick,” she said.

“Will the doctor be back soon?” asked Harry. “Or could you let us know how we could contact them?”

“Dr. Geiisshardt is sick,” she repeated. “And I’m not allowed to give out personal information.”

She glowered at us icily. Harry continued to trying his smooth words, but they seemed to be having the opposite effect from earlier in the day.

“Uhm, we’ll come back later,” said Hattie, leading us out before we had security or something called on us.

We sat down on some benches outside the building.

“Well, what now?” Harry asked, seeming a bit miffed that he hadn’t been able to sweet talk us past the secretary.

“Something’s up with that girl,” said Joanne. “Did you hear her accent? I don’t think she’s American.” She looked up at the rest of us “Not that there’s anything inherently wrong with that, but I don’t trust her.”

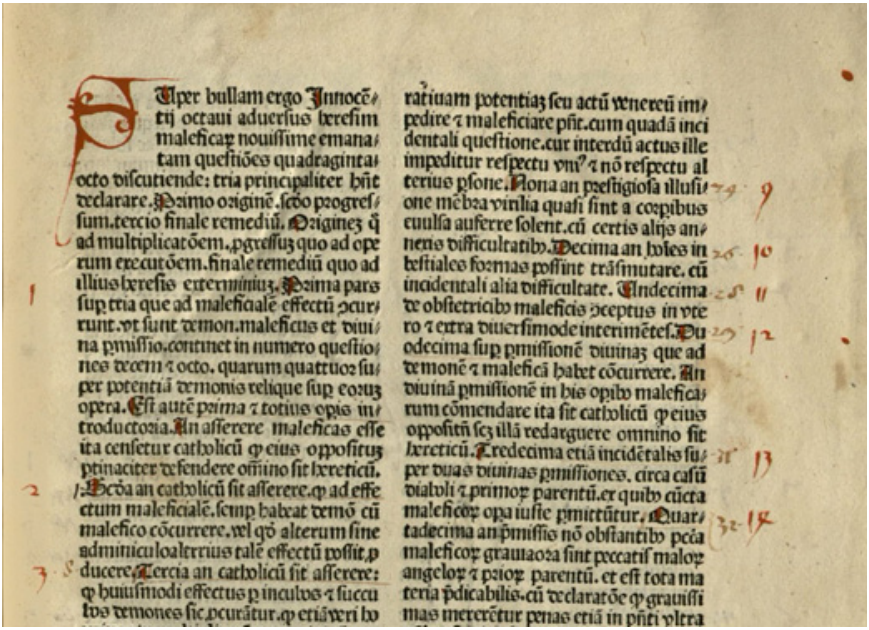
“I agree,” said Hattie. “There’s definitely something up with this whole situation. I think we need to get into her office somehow.”

“Well, I don’t think that’s going to happen with that b-, uh, secretary there,” I said. “Let’s come back later when she’s gone.”

“But who’ll let us in then?” began Joanne, before realization dawned on her face.

We headed back to the library to see what the others had learned. It turned out that they’d been far more successful in their afternoon than we had, and had managed to translate part of the book, and even find a few other sources that described it’s contents.

"The Malleus Maleficarum is a book from late 15th century Germany, written by Heinrich Kramer" began Lawrence. "It's also known as Der Hexenhammer, or "The Hammer of the Witches"."



"It's main purpose was to refute arguments that witches didn't exist," said Ernestine taking over. "And help magistrates find and persecute witches. It's split into three sections, the first refuting those who deny the existence of magic or witchcraft, the second describing magic, and the third telling how to confront and combat witchcraft."

"Okay," I began. "But that doesn't tell us why it's being stolen."

"Well," said Lawrence. "It's obvious that it's not the book itself that is so valuable, but a specific edition of the book, or the thief would have stopped with just one copy. There's nothing inherently dangerous about the contents of this book, and the fact that there are translations and discussions of the book that haven't been taken indicates that it's not the contents either."

"So somebody's looking for a specific copy of this book" I said. "That could take years!"

“You might think so,” said Ernestine. “And for a modern published book you might be right, but for something published hundreds of years ago there are considerably fewer copies around, even including the numerous reprints over the years.”

“Well we came up with something too!” proclaimed Joanna. “There’s totally something suspicious happening with this doctor, and all we have to do is break into their office.”

“Quiet!” I hissed. “We don’t need to broadcast that to the world.”

We discussed what we’d learned about the doctor at the office, which was basically nothing, and agreed to meet up near the building the good doctor’s office was in later that night.

When we got back Joanne was loaded down with ropes and other gear. “What’s all that for?” I asked. “To get in the window!” she said pointing up to the third floor where the office was. “Good idea” I said.

“I’ve got a better one,’ said Harry. “Let’s just go in the front door.” He dangled a set of keys to us.”

“How did you-” began Hattie before being interrupted.

“Perhaps it’s better if you didn’t know,” said Harry, smiling.

He led us towards the door, which opened easily to his keys. Of course we didn’t want to spend too much time hanging around outside so we quickly made our way upstairs and into the outer office, closing the doors behind us.

“Huh,” said Harry. “None of the keys are working on this door.” He indicated towards what was, of course, the office door we needed to get into. We spent a few futile minutes searching through the office, but weren’t able to find anything that would help.

“Can anyone pick locks?” I asked halfheartedly testing the solid door’s strength and wishing, not for the first time, that I’d bothered to check out that book on locksmithing I kept looking at back home.

“No, but I think the window might be open,” said Joanne, pointing to the small window in the office wall that she’d been investigating.

I poked my head out the window, and sure enough the next one over looked like it was ajar, and there was a small ledge running along the side of the building. “You sure about this?” I asked. “Yes,” she said with determination that I wasn’t sure was legitimate or just covering fear. She wrapped a rope around her middle and passed some into my hands. “Don’t drop it,” she said heading out the window before any of us could question whether this was a good idea.

She edged the fifteen or so feet along the ledge until her hands gripped the window frame. She pulled the other window open the entire way and managed to clamber inside. Quickly we heard the sound of a lock opening and the office door opened before us. “Ta dah!” she proclaimed. “Easy as pie.”

We entered the room and were astounded. The room was packed full of books, and not just any books, but that damn Malleus Maleficarum. Dozens of copies of it. I flicked through a few of them, but they all seemed to be pretty much the same.

“Oh!” said Hattie brandishing a copy in front of her. “This is our copy! Look at the stamp!”

“Well, I guess we know who our book thief is,” I said. “Now we just have to know why.”

The others started looking through the stacks of books, hoping to find the ones that had been taken from their libraries. I figured I could always do that later and started searching the desk for clues as to who this Dr. Geiisshaardt really was, and why they were after this book. It didn’t take me long before I found a datebook, which from previous experience can be a most useful book if you’re trying to find out about someone. Most of it seemed fairly average for a professor: classes, meetings, and the like, but as I flipped through it I realized that the end of it was completely empty.

I back tracked to find the last entry, and wouldn’t you know, it was for the current week. There was just one thing listed: “Graf Zep-

pelin" written on the page for Thursday the 26th. I flicked through the book again and a postcard fell out. It had a picture of the World's Fair Sky Ride on one side, while the other just had "26 Mittwoch Mitternacht" scrawled on the reverse.

Meanwhile Hattie had been digging through the trash next to the desk. "I think you'll want to see this Garrett," she said, putting together what looked like ripped up pieces of an ID card. I looked at it, and at first nothing jumped out about it to me. Just some girl I thought. Then I saw the name printed on the card: Nevilla Norman. The Snakeoid's sister. What are the chances? "We should tell Frank as soon as possible," said Hattie.

I was about to agree when Harry held up a book and said "Take a look at this too." By this point in my life you'd think I'd actually look at what was in front of my eyes before jumping to conclusions, but that hasn't happened yet.

"Found your library's copy of the book?" I asked.

"No," said Harry, with a hint of frustration in his voice. "Actually look at it. It's a copy of Mein Kampf."

"Nazis,"I said, my mind flashing back to my previous encounters with them. They'd only taken power in Germany earlier that year, but they were already causing problems in America.

BANGBANGBANG

Before I had a chance to think any further a fist pounded on the closed office door, quickly followed by a voice. "This is the Chicago Police Department, we have you surrounded, please surrender peacefully."

To be continued.

Bios//Bios

Ean Henninger isn't even a real librarian, and his presence in this work is a blatant sham. If he ever does get a Master's in the field, UBC is a prime choice, but for the time being, he will keep working at his local library and being a mellow young upstart at librarean.tumblr.com.

Adena Brons is an unpredictable, heroic exorcist who had a near-death experience that changed them significantly.

Irina Jevlakova is an industrious, odd magical inventor from another dimension who fears the future.

Matthew Murray is a weary, miserable starship engineer who was granted strange abilities by an alien species. You can find him on Twitter @midnitelibrary.

Image credits

Cover image by Steve Ditko (!) from The Thing! #13, published by Charlton Comics, April 1954. It's in the public domain!
It's for a story called Library of Horror (also drawn by Ditko, no writer credited) that doesn't even feature a library. Geeze.

Photos on pages 2-4 from the Boston Public Library Flickr.
Photo on page 5 from the thejourney1972 on Flickr.

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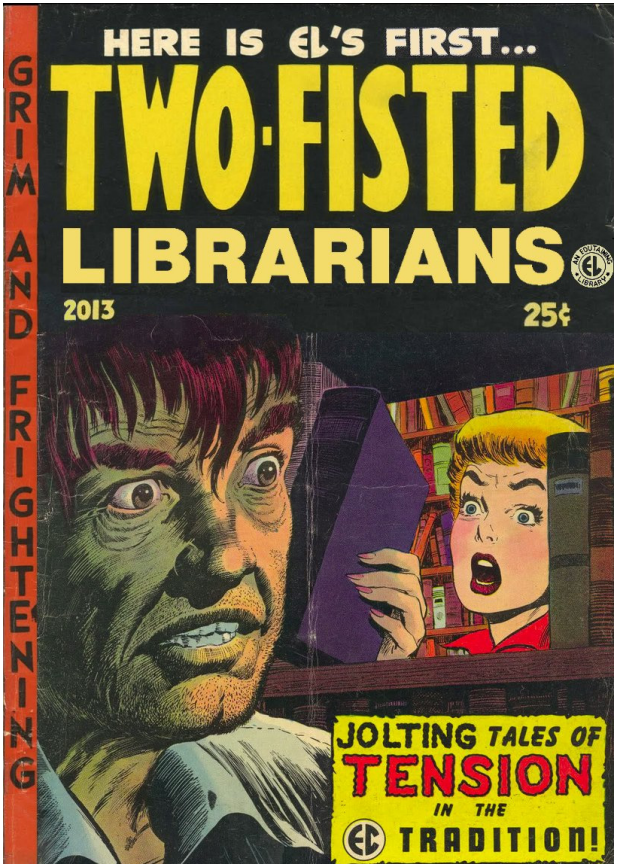
Two Fisted Librarians #2. Published May 2014, Vancouver, BC.



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Issue #3 is coming soon!

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